





FAST GAME Clockwise from top, Amarinder Singh Raja Warring, former Punjab CM Charanjit Singh Channi and Sachin Pilot

Takeaways

- **Sachin Pilot's mediation had yielded a truce: Warring was eased out as state chief, Pargat came in, in the last mile to assembly poll**
- **But no sign of dissidence waning, as Warring joins the ranks of the disillusioned, boycotting Pargat's official meets, holding his own**
- **Ex-CM Channi's ambitions main spur for factional war—he still aims to reclaim throne if Congress wins**
- **Now, Congress, BJP, AAP—all have state chiefs with roots in other parties. Pargat is an Akali import**

much. A July armistice he brokered between Warring and Channi went in vain: one count put leaders who wanted Warring out at over 90. Result: Baghel had to move out. On September 5, Pilot came in.

EVERYONE PASSES TO HIM

Pilot's soft diplomacy seemed to work, but not before a twist. Pargat was not first choice—Vijay Inder Singla was a hot tip till the end. But Warring reportedly argued against anyone close to Channi. That rang the coronation bell for the three-term Jalandhar Cantonment MLA, a Jat Sikh like Warring. The fullback was a fallback. Pargat played it gently, letting the hockey metaphors flow. "I've always played at the back. There are very good players in our team," he said, promising a consensus approach. Warring had worked hard, he added. "Rajaji is a player of our team. The issue is Punjab."

That's understating it. Punjab's Congress chiefs have rarely been left to run the party. Amarinder fought Bajwa, then Navjot Sidhu. Sidhu fought Channi, Randhawa, Bittu. Warring fought Channi. Now, Pargat fights Warring. Each time, chieftainship doubled as a claim on chief ministership. That question is wide open—Channi's camp has unilaterally projected him. Delhi will be mindful of the 2022 rout under him, but also that he can't be easily bypassed, nor his network ignored.

Now, there are Pargat's own dribbling skills to consider: he's an ex-Akali, who nimbly flitted across factions. A symmetry of sorts prevails now: BJP state chief Kewal Dhillon was a Congressman, so was AAP's Aman Arora. Under an ex-Akali MLA, the Congress is retesting the conceptual and practical limits of loyalty. On October 14, in Mansa, after anti-drug crusader Parvinder Singh Jhota was shot dead, Pargat asked if punitive demolition was fair as bulldozers moved against the alleged assassin's house. Channi, at his side, did not lend support when crowds hooted him down. By October 21, Pargat had found safer ground, attacking Amit Shah's Punjab visit. ■

AN OLD DILEMMA HAS RESURFACED IN Jammu and Kashmir: it comes packaged as 'reform', a good thing, but as they say, there can be too much of a good thing. A new law designed to fast-track investment is triggering sharp reactions from Opposition leaders, urban planners and civil society groups. The Ease of Doing Business Act, 2026, hands the chief minister sweeping powers to override master plans and ease the conversion of farmland, evoking fears that Kashmir's delicate landscape may be permanently harmed.

Passed during the recent autumn session of the assembly, the EoDB Bill—now an Act—would gladden those who point to India's regulatory cholesterol with its can-do language. It overhauls procedures for approvals, registrations, licences and clearances for enterprises. It seeks to "replace permission-based control with rule-based governance" and enable citizens and enterprises to "plan, invest and work with confidence....in a manner that generates employment, attracts investment, and sustains long-term economic growth" in J&K.

A FAST-TRACKED LAW

Its own fast-tracking was a model for ease of doing legislative business. Published in an extraordinary issue of the J&K Official Gazette on September 24, CM Omar Abdullah introduced it on September 28; it was passed the next day, and green-lit by the Lieutenant Governor on October 1. But public scrutiny is growing, with warnings that its all-too-easy provisions would "wreak havoc" in urban areas and "mortgage the ecological security of the future generations" of Kashmir.

The Group of Concerned Citizens, a civil society group of former bureaucrats led by Khursheed Ahmad Ganai, ex-advisor to the Governor, sounded the alarm at a Srinagar press conference on October 9. The legislation, they say, will promote "feverish, pervasive and large-scale construction" in a way that will "negatively impact" human lives and the environment. "J&K